

8 > Choose your format and design your podcast

Start with your strengths

Do not choose a format because it looks impressive. Choose one you can execute consistently.

Ask yourself four questions:

1. Are you comfortable speaking alone for several minutes?
2. Are you naturally good at interviewing people?
3. Do you enjoy research, scripting and detailed editing?
4. Do you have a co-host whose schedule and commitment match yours?

Your answers immediately narrow the possibilities. A confident subject expert may thrive with a solo show. Someone who is curious and conversational may be better suited to interviews. A journalist or storyteller might prefer narrative episodes. Two friends with strong chemistry may create a compelling co-hosted programme.

Understand the main podcast formats

1) Solo commentary

The host speaks directly to the audience, usually around one topic per episode. This works well for education, analysis, opinion, tutorials and personal expertise.

The challenge is maintaining energy without another voice, so solo episodes need strong structure and examples.

2) One-to-one interviews

A host speaks with one guest. This is one of the most accessible formats because guests contribute much of the knowledge and variety.

Good interview shows still need preparation, active listening and questions that reveal something useful.

3) Co-hosted conversations

Two regular presenters discuss a subject together. The advantage is natural chemistry, disagreement and humour. The downside is dependency: if one person repeatedly cancels, production stops.



Before launching, co-hosts should agree on responsibilities, ownership, money, decision-making and what happens if one person eventually leaves.

4) Round-table discussions

Three or more speakers discuss a topic. Panels can provide diverse viewpoints, especially for news, sport, technology and culture.

They are harder to manage, so a strong moderator is essential.

5) Narrative and documentary podcasts

These combine narration, interviews, archive material, music and sound design. They can be powerful, but demand significant research and post-production.

6) News and analysis

These shows respond to current events and therefore depend on speed. A daily programme can build strong habits among listeners, but the workload is relentless.

If you are producing the show alone, a weekly news analysis format may be more sustainable than promising daily episodes.

7) Question-and-answer formats

Listeners submit questions that the host answers. This format is especially useful for education, careers, finance, health, technology and hobbies. It can also create a strong sense of community because the audience helps shape future episodes.

8) Hybrid shows

You do not have to use one format forever. A show may publish a major interview every week and a short solo explainer between interviews. The key is predictability. Listeners should understand what each episode type offers.

Decide the length of each episode

There is no universally correct podcast length. An episode should be long enough to deliver its promise and no longer.

Do not stretch a 20-minute idea into an hour, or crush a valuable 75-minute conversation into 30 minutes simply to meet an arbitrary target.

Use these questions:

- How complex is the subject?
- When is your listener likely to consume the show?
- How much preparation can you sustain?
- How long can you remain engaging?
- How much editing time does the format require?

A commuter-focused practical show might target 20 to 30 minutes. A detailed expert interview could run 45 to 60 minutes. Narrative episodes may vary depending on the story.

Pick a target range rather than an exact duration. For example, “most episodes will run 25 to 35 minutes.” This creates consistency without making every recording artificial.